CINEMA ▼

# SPOTLIGHTING *the Female POV*

**FOUR FILMMAKERS EXPLORE FEMALE DESIRE, AGENCY AND THE CHANGING LANGUAGE OF LUST IN THE THIRD EDITION OF *LUST STORIES***

**Vishal Bhardwaj thinks it is the best format; Vikramaditya Motwane loved** that it required just five days of shoot; Kiran Rao likes the discipline of making one; and Shakun deliberated with the duration. All four filmmakers contribute a short each to the third iteration of the anthology film, *Lust Stories* (Netflix). Interestingly, all look at desire largely through a female gaze. For Ruchikaa Kapoor Sheikh, Director, Original Films, at Netflix India, this was intentional. But "none of the characters subscribe to a stereotype," she says.

In Bhardwaj's Hyderabad-set period work, actor Siddharth is seen predominantly in a small white towel as he appears as an object of his writer wife's (Aditi Rao Hydari) wild imagination. "We always objectify a female in movies, so why not do it to a man for a change?" asks Vishal. "I am so glad Siddharth was sporting about it."

Rao admits that the male lead in her short (Gurfateh Pirzada) operates as a "thirst trap". The short sees two young migrants with "electric chemistry" who are "comfortable to express their sensuality" in the confines of a working-class neighbourhood in Mumbai. For Rao, it was an opportunity to show how uninhibited passion is for the youth. "They have a sense of confidence and the ability to express themselves, which is both fascinating and inspiring," she says.

In Batra's short, lust becomes a "coping mechanism" as things fall apart for a couple (Ali Fazal and Radhika Madan). "They don't understand love in the same language," says Batra. "There's power dynamics communicated through lust...when we stop communicating, then bodies do so with rage, grief and more."

The best and funniest of the pack is Motwane's, which has a cracking ensemble in Konkona Sensharma, Radhika Apte, Vijay Varma and Abhishek Banerjee. For Motwane and his writer Avinash Sampath, showing a woman's perspective on lust was necessary because for the longest time patriarchy "never allowed" them to do so. Fittingly so that it's the two actresses who are in riotous form as building friends who plan to swap their husbands to liven up their sexless marriages. There's also an interesting look at how K-dramas have spoiled female audiences with their depiction of idyllic men. "The push and pull of very middle-class India and Korean lifestyle was too delicious to ignore," he says. "There's no thirst trap happening, the lust is real and it's not elevating anybody." ■

***—Suhani Singh***



***THE SHORTS RANGE FROM A PERIOD PIECE TO A PASSIONATE ROMANCE, A TRAGIC RELATIONSHIP TO A COMEDY ON SEXLESS DOMESTICITY***